

PHASE 3: ACTIVATION PLAYBOOK

Brian Edition • UX Cerebro Framework

Weaponizing your authentic story for real-world UX career success

This document translates the 7 Power Moves into a concrete, tactical playbook. Everything here is built from your specific background, your exact language, and the evidence we uncovered in your career timeline. Use it before every application, before every interview, and every time you doubt whether your path is enough. It is.

SECTION 01 — DOMINATING INTERVIEWS

Your Knockout Story Arsenal

These are built from real moments in your timeline. Each story follows the Situation → Action → Result structure. Memorize the spine. Let the language be natural.

STORY 1 — The Binding Rolls

SITUATION

In my first warehouse job, binding materials for carpet rugs weren't organized by color. Every time I needed to color-match a carpet, I was hunting through a pile of rolls — and a wrong shade sewn in meant starting over.

WHAT I DID

Without being asked, I organized the entire binding inventory by color family. I thought about the person coming after me on the next task — not just my own workflow. It took extra time upfront, but it eliminated the hunt entirely.

RESULT / INSIGHT

Coworkers told me it made their work faster and easier. This was before I had any language for 'design thinking' — but I was already doing it: spotting friction, understanding the user's next step, fixing the system rather than working around it.

🔗 **USE THIS WHEN:** Any question about how you approach problems, process improvement, or 'tell me about a time you improved a workflow.'

STORY 2 — The Resident and the Movie

SITUATION

Working overnight shifts in direct care, I was managing bedtime transitions for adults with developmental disabilities. One night, a resident was almost done with his movie — ten more

minutes. My instinct was to let him finish. A supervisor overrode me and demanded he turn it off immediately.

WHAT I DID

I read the situation correctly. I understood that a few minutes of grace would make the transition smooth. The supervisor had positional authority but not situational awareness. I froze in the moment — I didn't push back when I should have.

RESULT / INSIGHT

The resident escalated. Physical restraint was required — exactly what a smooth transition would have prevented. I learned something I've carried since: knowing the right answer means nothing if you don't advocate for it. I design for the user who can't advocate for themselves. But I also have to be willing to advocate for them.

🔊 **USE THIS WHEN:** Questions about handling conflict, working with authority, or 'tell me about a mistake you learned from.'

STORY 3 — The Phone Repair Customers

SITUATION

Customers came into Tech Boys frustrated and confused. Their phone was 'waterproof' — they'd used a screen protector — but it still cracked. They felt misled by the manufacturer's marketing and embarrassed that they didn't understand what had happened.

WHAT I DID

I met them where they were. I didn't explain specs at them — I explained it the way a person who owns a phone would understand it. I validated their frustration because I felt it too. I was that user. I helped them understand without making them feel stupid.

RESULT / INSIGHT

Customers left calmer and better informed. But I also recognized the upstream problem: the gap between how durability was marketed and what customers actually experienced. I saw the design failure, not just the support ticket. That's the lens I bring to every research conversation.

🔊 **USE THIS WHEN:** Questions about user research, empathy, 'how do you handle frustrated users,' or 'tell me about a time you had to explain something complex.'

STORY 4 — The Curriculum Change

SITUATION

In my UX program, all projects were solo. I could see that collaborative projects — the kind that mirror real-world team environments — were being used at other programs and producing better outcomes. The solo model wasn't preparing us for how design actually works.

WHAT I DID

I raised it with my instructor directly. I said I thought group projects would better reflect professional practice and asked if they'd consider building that in. They agreed it was a good idea.

RESULT / INSIGHT

They implemented it — I saw group projects introduced into the curriculum. I didn't get to participate before I graduated, but the change happened. I identified a systemic gap, spoke up, and it moved. That's what I do in design: find what's not working for the people in the room, and say so.

🔗 **USE THIS WHEN:** Questions about proactively identifying problems, influencing without authority, or 'give me an example of driving change.'

STORY 5 — The Apple ID Friction

SITUATION

In my current role managing a smartphone repair location, we see the same friction point every single day: customers can't complete their repair because they've forgotten their Apple ID password. Apple requires device access for certain repairs. No password, no progress. The customer waits. The repair is delayed.

WHAT I DID

I identified that Google already solved this problem with Repair Mode — a feature that lets a device be serviced without exposing personal data or requiring full account access. Apple doesn't have an equivalent. I've been observing this pattern daily and documenting the friction in my head.

RESULT / INSIGHT

This is real-world UX research happening in a retail environment. I'm watching a systemic failure affect real users every day. I know what the fix looks like. I haven't yet found the right channel to escalate to Apple — but I'm naming it clearly, and that instinct to see the system behind the symptom is exactly what I bring into a design role.

🔗 **USE THIS WHEN:** Questions about research in the field, identifying systemic problems, or 'how do you stay connected to users day-to-day.'

Answer Frameworks for Common Questions

"Tell me about yourself"

I'm a UX designer who came up through real-world experience before formal training. I spent years in retail and direct care watching people get failed by products and systems not built for them. That experience — plus a UX degree — gives me something most designers don't have: I've been the overlooked user. I design for that person because I remember what it felt like.

"What's your design process?"

I start with the person who's most likely to struggle — not the average user, but the one who's already skeptical that this will work for them. I do research to find what they're embarrassed to admit, not just what they'll say out loud. Then I prototype, test with that harder use case, and iterate. If it works for the struggling user, it works for everyone.

"What's your greatest weakness?"

I've historically stayed quiet when I saw something wrong — especially when there was an authority figure involved. I've been working on that directly. I've gotten better at naming what I see and advocating for it clearly. It's actually why I'm drawn to UX research: it gives me a structured, credible way to say 'the system is failing these users — here's the evidence.'

"Why UX?"

I didn't choose UX because I wanted to make things pretty. I chose it because I kept watching real people get confused, give up, or feel stupid when systems weren't built for them. I knew what that felt like personally. UX was the only discipline where fixing that was the actual job.

"Where do you see yourself in 5 years?"

Doing research and design for products that actually reach people who've been written off — whether that's accessibility, health tech, financial tools, or public services. I want to raise the floor of who gets good design, not just optimize experiences for people who were already going to be fine.

Power Closing Questions

Ask these at the end of an interview. They position you as a systems thinker and a partner, not just a candidate.

- "Who is the user your team finds hardest to design for — and how are you currently approaching that?"
- "What's a design decision your team made recently that you'd approach differently with more research time?"
- "How does this team handle disagreement between research findings and stakeholder preferences?"
- "Where does the team feel like the current product is failing its users?"
- "What would make someone exceptional in this role — not just good?"

Your One-Liners and Sound Bites

Memorize these. They're your air cover in any conversation.

"I didn't come up through a design school — I came up through the school of watching real people get failed by systems that weren't built for them. That's not a gap in my resume. That's my competitive edge."

"I don't just solve usability problems — I design for the user who already expects to fail. When they don't, that's the win."

"My superpower is turning empathy into insight — I don't just listen to what users say, I notice what they're embarrassed to admit. That's where the real design problems live."

"The biggest mistake in UX is designing for the user you wish you had. I design for the user you actually have."

"My mission is to raise the floor of who gets good design — not just build for the already-confident, but for everyone who's been quietly written off."

SECTION 02 — YOUR CAN'T-IGNORE PORTFOLIO

Hero Case Study Structure

Your hero case study should anchor your portfolio. It needs to embody Power Moves 01, 02, 03, and 05 — your origin, your victory, your secret weapon, and your mission. Here's the structure:

THE HOOK (FIRST SCREEN — MAKE THEM FEEL IT)

Open with the user, not the process. Something like:

"This project started with a question I couldn't stop thinking about: Who gets written off when this product doesn't work for them?"

Name the user population you were designing for and why they're overlooked. Make the reader feel the problem before you show them the solution.

THE PROBLEM FRAMING

- State the official design brief in one sentence
- Then reframe it through your lens: 'But the real problem was...'
- Name specifically who was being underserved and what they were experiencing
- This is where Power Move 06 lives — you design for the actual user, not the idealized one

YOUR RESEARCH APPROACH

- Lead with your Socratic method — how you asked questions that helped users discover their own pain, not just describe it
- Name the non-verbal cues you picked up on — the hesitations, the embarrassment, the workarounds
- Show synthesis: how you moved from raw observation to insight
- Include a quote or finding that captures what users couldn't say directly but showed in their behavior

THE DESIGN DECISIONS

- Show 2-3 key decisions, each with the 'why' connected to a specific research insight
- Show what you considered and rejected — this demonstrates design judgment, not just output
- Include iterations: before/after screens with the reasoning

THE OUTCOME + REFLECTION

- Share results if you have them — usability test findings, improved task completion, feedback
- If academic: frame it as 'what would have happened' with honest hypotheticals
- End with what you'd do differently — this shows maturity and self-awareness
- Close with the mission statement from Power Move 05: connect this project to why you do this work

Framing Additional Portfolio Pieces

Piece 2 — The Research-Led Project

Use this to showcase Power Move 03 (Secret Weapon). Lead with the research method, not the UI output. Structure it as: 'Here's what users said → here's what they actually meant → here's what I did about it.' This piece should make a research lead or UX researcher sit up straight.

Piece 3 — The Systems Observation Project

This is where your Apple ID / repair flow observation lives — even without formal employment as a UX designer. Document the friction. Map the current flow. Show the gap. Propose the fix. You don't need to have been paid to do UX research to show you think like a researcher. You've been doing field research every day in your retail role. Write it up as a case study.

Working title: "A Repair Experience Audit: How a Missing Feature Fails Customers Every Day"

The Narrative Arc Across Your Portfolio

Every piece in your portfolio should connect to the same through-line. A recruiter scrolling your work should feel this arc:

- **Piece 1:** I understand overlooked users because I've been one. My research goes deeper because of it.
- **Piece 2:** Here's my research method in action — this is how I turn empathy into evidence.
- **Piece 3:** I see design problems in the wild — even in my day job. I can't turn this off.

That arc says: This is a designer with a point of view, a method, and a mission. Hire them before someone else does.

Testimonial Strategy

You don't need a lot of testimonials. You need the right ones. Here's who to ask and what to prompt them toward:

UX Instructor / Professor

Ask them to speak to your research instincts and your ability to ask the right questions — not just your technical skills.

Classmate / Collaborator

Ask them to speak to what it was like working through a design problem with you — specifically the moment your perspective changed how they thought about it.

Anyone you've helped navigate something

Ask them to describe what it was like when you explained something confusing in a way that finally clicked. That's a UX superpower — make it visible.

Prompting language you can send them:

"I'm building my UX portfolio and I'd love a short quote from you. I'm not looking for general praise — I'd love it if you could speak to a specific moment where you saw my research instincts or empathy for users in action. Even a sentence or two would mean a lot."

SECTION 03 — STRATEGIC CAREER ADVANCEMENT

Skills to Double Down On

User Research Methods	You're already strong here instinctively. Now formalize it. Study: Jobs-to-be-Done framework, contextual inquiry, think-aloud protocols, affinity diagramming. Resource: Nielsen Norman Group articles (free), 'Just Enough Research' by Erika Hall.
Synthesis + Insight Generation	This is your real edge — turning raw observation into design direction. Deepen it with: How Might We exercises, insight statement writing, opportunity mapping. Resource: IDEO Design Kit (free online).
Case Study Writing	Your stories are powerful. Now get them on a page in a format that hiring managers read in 3 minutes. Study: best-in-class UX case studies on uxfolio.com and Bestfolios.com. Analyze structure, not just visuals.
Systems Thinking	You naturally see systems (binding rolls, Apple ID flow, curriculum structure). Sharpen this with: service blueprinting, ecosystem mapping, Jobs-to-be-Done theory. This positions you for senior roles faster.
Figma Proficiency	Make sure your tool fluency isn't a question mark. Focus on components, auto-layout, and prototyping — the areas most likely to come up in design exercises. Resource: Figma's own YouTube tutorials.

Target Role Profiles

ROLES TO TARGET

- UX Researcher (Associate / Junior)
- UX Designer with research emphasis
- Product Designer at mission-driven companies
- UX Designer at civic tech, health tech, or fintech companies serving underserved populations
- Accessibility-focused design roles

KEYWORDS TO LOOK FOR IN JOB POSTINGS

- "Empathy-driven" or "human-centered"
- "Mixed methods research"
- "Underserved users," "accessibility," or "equity"
- "Cross-functional collaboration"
- "Research-to-design" or "research-informed"
- "Inclusive design" or "design for all"

RED FLAGS TO AVOID

- "Move fast" paired with no mention of research or testing
- "Polish existing UI" as the primary job description — you'll be bored and underused
- Companies where 'design' reports into marketing only
- Roles that list 20+ hard skills — they don't know what they want
- Job postings with no mention of users, customers, or research at all

Green Flag Companies

Look for companies that share your mission — designing for the overlooked, the underserved, the people who've been written off. These categories are your hunting ground:

- **Civic Tech:** USDS (US Digital Service), Code for America, Nava PBC, Ad Hoc — all building government services for people who have no other option
- **Health Tech:** Companies focused on patient experience, mental health access, or health equity — where the stakes of bad UX are highest
- **Financial Inclusion:** Companies serving unbanked or underbanked communities — fintech with a mission, not just an app
- **Accessibility-Forward:** Microsoft's inclusive design team, Apple Accessibility, companies that center disability in their design process
- **Nonprofits with digital products:** They often need strong UX help and will value your mission alignment

Your positioning statement for these companies:

"I build for the user who already assumes this product wasn't made for them. When I get it right, they feel that — and that's the kind of retention and loyalty that matters."

SECTION 04 — POWER NETWORKING

Your 30-Second Intro — 3 Versions

Use the right version for the right context. All three are true. All three are yours.

VERSION 1 — WARM (CASUAL, CONVERSATIONAL)

"I'm a UX designer. I came to design a little differently than most — I spent years in retail working directly with real people before I got my degree. That experience gave me something I couldn't have gotten in a classroom: I've watched people get confused, give up, and feel stupid because products weren't made for them. I design so that stops happening."

VERSION 2 — BOLD (FOR CONFERENCES, PANELS, OR COLD INTROS)

"I'm a UX designer with a background that most designers don't have — years of real-world retail experience watching real users struggle with products every single day. I design for the person who already expects to fail. Most UX work ignores that person. I don't."

VERSION 3 — STORY-LED (FOR LONGER INTRO MOMENTS OR INTERVIEWS)

"Before UX was ever on my radar, I was the person users came to when something wasn't working. In a warehouse, in direct care, in phone repair — I kept ending up in the same place: watching people struggle with systems that weren't built for them, and trying to fix it. Eventually I realized there was a whole discipline built around that instinct. So I went and got the degree. Now I do it on purpose."

LinkedIn Engagement Strategy

WHO TO FOLLOW

- UX researchers and designers at civic tech companies (USDS, Nava, Code for America)
- Designers who write publicly about inclusive design and accessibility
- Hiring managers and recruiters at mission-driven tech companies
- UX educators and bootcamp instructors (they often share job leads and opportunities)
- People doing research at the intersection of tech and social impact

WHAT TO COMMENT — YOUR ENGAGEMENT PLAYBOOK

Don't just like posts. Comment with something that adds a layer. Your frame is always: the overlooked user, the system behind the symptom, the research question nobody asked. Examples:

When someone posts about a usability win: "This is great — I'm always curious who the edge case user was in this test. The ones who struggled most usually reveal the most."

When someone posts a hot take on UX trends: "The piece I'd add here is what this means for users who are already skeptical the product works for them. That group often gets left out of the conversation."

When someone shares research findings: "Curious how you handled the users who gave you 'polite' answers in sessions — that's usually where I try to dig deeper. What were they not saying?"

WHAT TO POST

- Observations from your retail work (anonymized) — real users, real friction, real insight
- Your take on Power Move 06: "The biggest mistake in UX is designing for the user you wish you had." Expand it into a post.
- The Apple ID repair flow observation — write it up as a short case study post
- Reflections on designing for overlooked users — connect your personal experience to your professional mission

How to Add Value in Conversations

Networking conversations don't have to be transactional. You have something genuine to offer. Use your natural Socratic instinct.

- Ask about the hardest user they've had to design for — most designers love this question and rarely get asked it
- Share an observation from your retail work that's relevant to what they're building — you have real-world data most designers don't have
- Offer your perspective on a design problem they mention — not to solve it, but to add a layer they might not have considered
- Ask what's frustrating them about their current design process — then listen without rushing to fix

Strategic Relationship Building

You don't need a huge network. You need a real one.

Weeks 1-2	Identify 10 people doing work you genuinely respect in your target space. Follow them. Read their content. Comment thoughtfully on 2-3 posts each.
Weeks 3-4	Send 3-5 connection requests with a personal note. Reference something specific they wrote or made. No ask. Just genuine connection.
Month 2	For anyone who's responded warmly: ask for a 20-minute conversation. Not about jobs. About their work. Come with 3 real questions.
Month 3+	Keep showing up. Comment regularly. Share your own observations. Be the person who adds value before they ask for anything.

Your outreach template (LinkedIn or email):

"Hi [Name] — I've been following your work on [specific thing] and it's been shaping how I think about [related topic]. I'm a UX designer early in my career, focused on designing for underserved and overlooked users. I'd love to ask you a couple of questions about how you approach [specific aspect of their work] — no agenda, just genuine curiosity. Would a 20-minute conversation be possible? Totally understand if not."

THE INTERNAL RESET

Read this before every application. Before every interview. Before every moment of doubt.

"I used to translate my background into something that sounded more 'acceptable.' I'm done translating. My path is the differentiator — and I'm ready to own it completely."

Brian is the UX designer who makes overlooked users feel like the product was finally built for them — because he's been that user, and he never forgot it.